



Society of Petroleum Engineers

SPE-229398-MS

Navigating Culture Complexities: Competency Base Training for Sustainable Culture Change

H. A. AL Harthy, Human Resource Department, Muscat, Oman / Shell Oman Development, Muscat, Oman / SHELL DEVELOPMET OMAN, MUSCAT, OMAN

Copyright 2025, Society of Petroleum Engineers DOI [10.2118/229398-MS](https://doi.org/10.2118/229398-MS)

This paper was prepared for presentation at the ADIPEC held in Abu Dhabi, UAE, 3 – 6 November 2025.

This paper was selected for presentation by an SPE program committee following review of information contained in an abstract submitted by the author(s). Contents of the paper have not been reviewed by the Society of Petroleum Engineers and are subject to correction by the author(s). The material does not necessarily reflect any position of the Society of Petroleum Engineers, its officers, or members. Electronic reproduction, distribution, or storage of any part of this paper without the written consent of the Society of Petroleum Engineers is prohibited. Permission to reproduce in print is restricted to an abstract of not more than 300 words; illustrations may not be copied. The abstract must contain conspicuous acknowledgment of SPE copyright.

Abstract

The objective of this abstract is to introduce a comprehensive diagnosis, competency training, and sustainable methodology that enables systematic transformation culture to change in the organization. The paper explains in depth the following topics:

- Culture audit - Identify subcultures (Management level, departments and regions) to understand the variation and the culture nuances.
- Define robust culture competency and tools to deliver culture transformation.
- Long-term sustainable system to reinforce the new desired culture.

This framework for culture transformation is grounded in targeted competency training programs, differentiated by management level, departments and mindsets to build a unique competence required to support the desired culture shift. The identified competencies is based on culture audit and company vision and it will range from inclusive leadership and change agility to accountability and collaboration through comprehensive training and tools. The competencies will tailor learning pathways and toolkit that will be developed for each management level.

The culture transformation will be processed in different segments (See Attached – [Figure 01](#)- "Process Map for culture change").

Implementing culture competency training that supports sustaining the shift in the culture that is tailored for each management level and mind set through the below segments:

Segment 1 - Defined and Diagnose: Develop a clear evidence-based picture of the existing culture and identify aspects of culture that supports the desired change. Output: Culture Gap analysis, change strategy, vision of culture, shareholders mapping.

Segment 2- Culture Design: Create culture change plan that is practical, measurable and aligned with the company value and desired culture. Output: Culture change roadmap, blueprint for aligning policies, processes with the desired culture, Competences and tools.

Segment 3- Deliver Desired Culture: implement culture vision and change. Output: Visible shifts in the mindset, terminologies, embedded culture practices used in the system, Increase employee's alignment and ownership.

Segment 4- Culture Reinforce and Sustain: solidify the culture change and mindset. Prevent regression to the old norms. Output: A self-driven culture organization (culture will become a DNA of the organization).

Note: For Segment 01 | 02 | 03| 04 - See Below Figure 02

Observation: It's recognized that defining culture training competency is very complex as it requires aligning diverse behaviors and values across all levels of the organization.

Introduction

Culture plays a vital role in every organization, especially in the long term. It reflects the principles, values, behavior and ways of work that guides how employees should interact, make decisions and solve issues. A positive and strong intentional culture helps not only the organizations but the natural teams to work together and improve their performance. With a great culture the organization will be able to attract talent, build trust and allow the organization to be agile and adapt to the fast-paced changes in the current world.

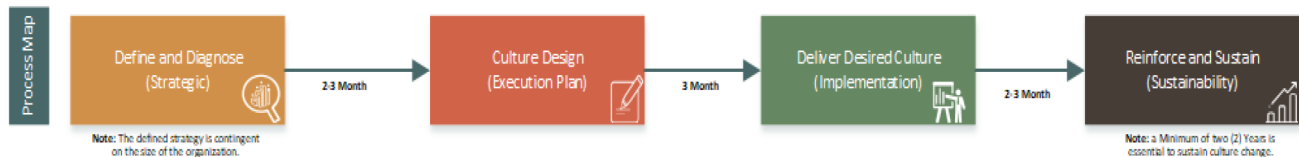


Figure 01—Process Map for Culture Change

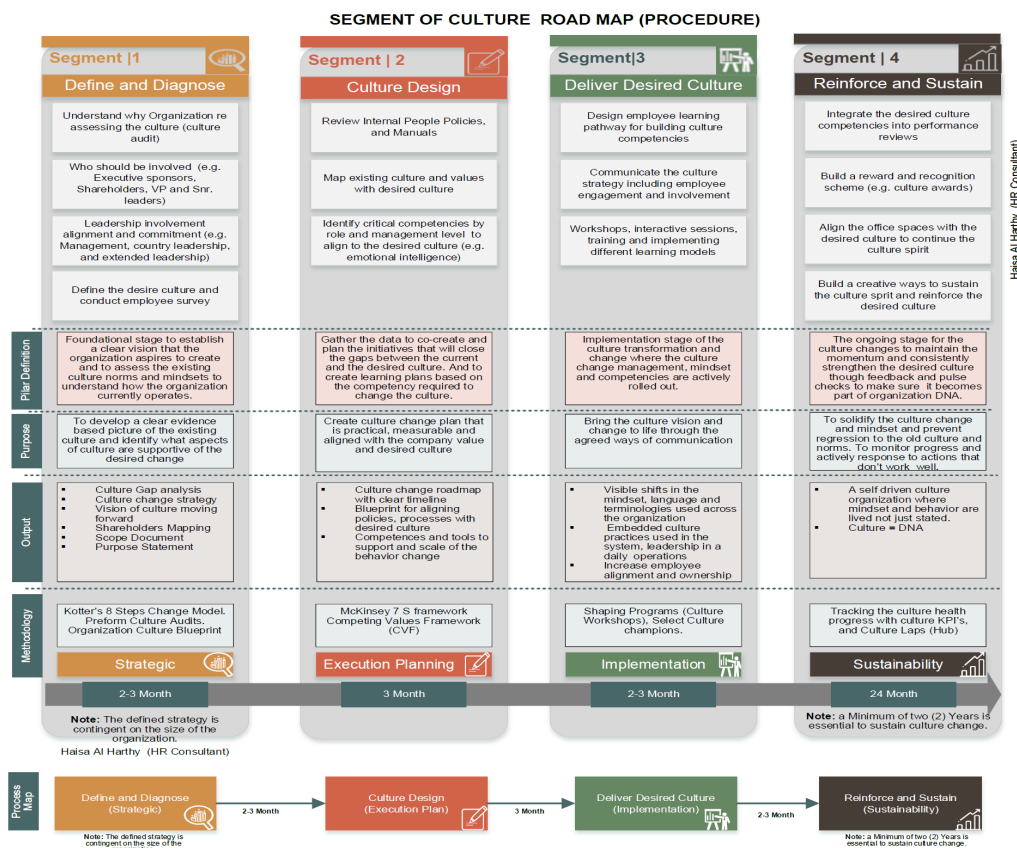


Figure 02—Segmentation of Culture – Road Map

Define and Diagnose (Strategic)



Purpose	: To develop a clear evidence-based picture of the existing culture and identify what aspects of culture are supportive of the desired change.
Time Frame	: 2-3 Month

Many organizations recognize the importance of culture and invest in the transformation, dedicating time, money and significant energy for the change, however its often launched as a short – term initiative or campaign typically at the start, there is always a high engagement and energy followed by gradual decline. All the engagement happens once or twice but without reinforced, hence the impact rarely lasts. Additionally, when driving the culture transformation, organizations overlook the complexities of the existing culture, history, leadership styles and informal norms. They fail to understand these nuances as they can lead to surface – level of changes that don't address the deeper culture challenges. True and lasting culture is not created though once off workshops and campaigns. It requires consistency across different channels and daily practice and tools to sustain the culture.

Define and diagnose the organization before the transformation

It is essential to first define what culture means to the organization context and why the organization decided to re-assess the culture now. The organization needs to conduct a structured diagnosis to understand the current culture landscape, without this foundational step transformation initiatives risk begin misaligned with the actual experience of employees leading to a short impact or a resistance of transformation. This step provides a clear vision of the culture norms, mindsets and how the organization currently operates. To define the culture the organization, need to look at the shared values, beliefs, behaviors and norms that guide how works get done including trust dynamics and decision-making process. During this phase all the levels in the organization need to be involved to understand what is being addressed and how the change will look like.

Key questions while diagnosing culture:

- What behavior are rewarded or punished?
- How to respond to failures or any risk appearing
- How is success defined at different levels
- What topics are openly discussed and avoided in the meeting.

Organization Culture Audit and Culture Assessment

To prepare for a successful culture transformation, the organization needs to understand the existing culture through culture audit and culture assessment (See [Table 01 - Culture Audit -Assessment](#)). Both are important as they provide a distinct insight and serve different purposes that will be needed in order to achieve the desired culture change. Majority of organizations focus on measuring the effectiveness of the current culture through culture assessment and forget to inspect the behaviors and informal norms. Below table provides the details of the impact they both have during the culture transformation.

Table 01—Culture Audit (Assessment)

Aspect	Culture Audit	Culture Assessment
Purpose:	Diagnostic evaluation and inspect the current state of the culture in depth	Measure the current culture effectiveness or alignments
Focus:	Leadership style, behavior, informal norms, level of engagement	How people experience culture, mindsets values
Scope:	Leadership behaviors, policies, rituals	Analytical through surveys or interviews or focus groups
Output:	Identification of misalignment, gaps, risks and enablers	General picture of SWOT analyses
Depth:	Deep and can be investigated	Boarder

First Diagnose (Culture Audit). A culture audit is a structured process to evaluate the current culture from a system and ways of work perspective, performance management, informal norms such as how decisions are made, who gets heard and what behavior are considered to be acceptable. It focuses on beliefs, norms and behavior patterns that define the environment. To conduct the culture audit, organizations need to:

1. Select a culture framework to provide a structured audit
2. Gather data
3. Analyse and Identify patterns

Edgar Schein's three level of culture is a foundational model that works very effectively in the culture audit. It helps to discover not only what employees do but why employees behave the way they behave. Schein's three level covers

1. Artifacts
2. Espoused values
3. Underlying assumption

The Audit in the organizations should start with Artifacts (visible elements) which are the office design, meeting behavior, rituals, communication style, symbols. This first audit happens in three stages:

- **Observing** the communication style, the interaction between the natural teams, behavior in the meeting and corridor talks.
- **Reviewing** the policies, processes, technology
- **Collecting** the evident data on how culture is displayed.

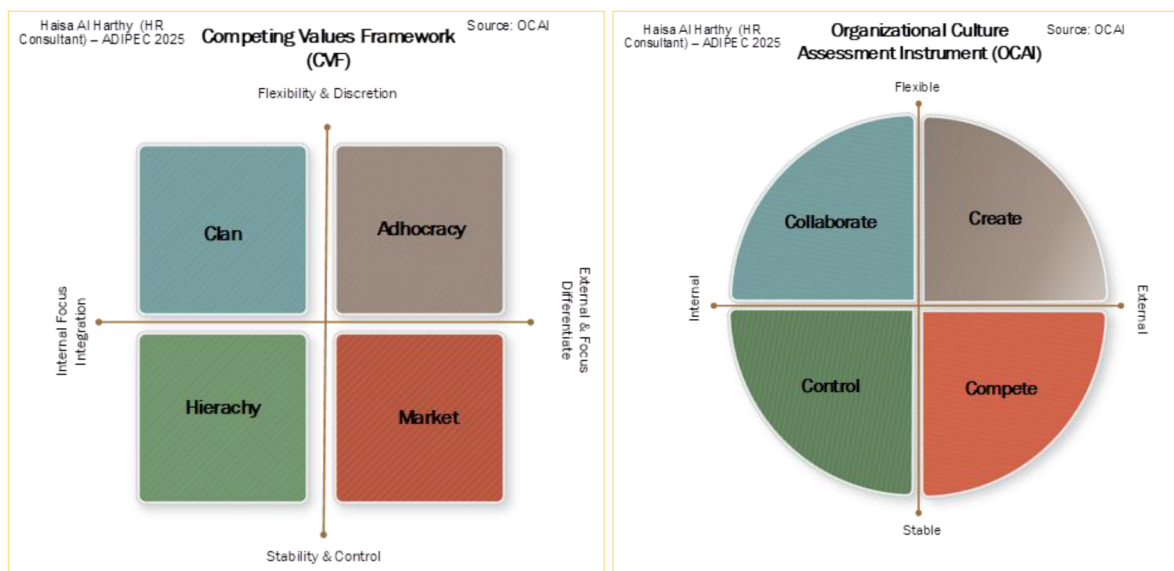
Once we have a clear understanding of what are noticeable rituals, traditions and routines in the teams and organization, we move to the next level of Edgar Schein's three levels of culture, Espoused values the current value (organization believes). This level will be for official principles, goals and missions. Example: "we value honesty" or "we believe on collaboration". During this phase the audit is happening in three stages:

- **Reviewing** the value statement, engagement messages, leadership communication and materials.
- **Interview** and understand from the leaders and employees the values they believe the organization stands for.

- **Observe** this the actual organization value vs. the experienced value (what the employees feel).

With this audit stage it will be clear which values the organization/ employees are practicing in a day-to-day basis. Then comes the most important and the last stage of the audit in Edgar Schein's three levels of culture, the underlying assumptions. Where the audit will be deep and tackling the unconscious beliefs that guide the behaviors. The unspoken and taken for granted. Example: "decisions are made in the side talk not a meeting room" or "leadership want results not feedback". The last stage will be:

- **Explore** the environment through interviews, deep listening, and focus groups.
- **Find** patterns of behavior that contradict with the current values
- **Identify** emotional reactions on the collaborations and failures or changes in the authority level.



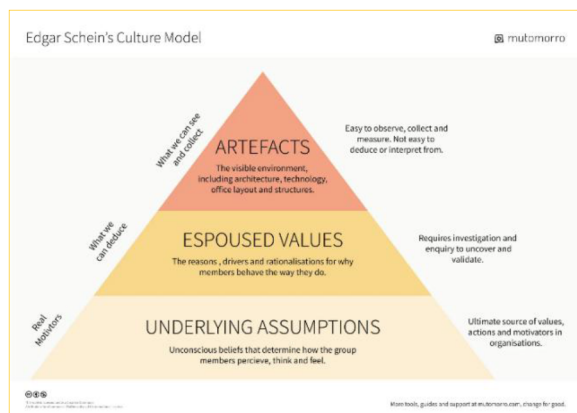
The last stage will provide the outcome of the underlined issues including what happens when someone challenges the leadership teams.

Using Edgar Schein's three levels of culture during the audit will provide a full structured way to capture the meta view of organizational behavior and the gaps between leadership perception and the employees' experience, it will also show the barriers that may resist the change. Having all these outcomes will help to easily decide where to intervene and what to focus on during the culture transformation.

Second Level Diagnose - Culture Assessment. Culture assessment is the second step to understand the organization and why they decided to transform the culture at this period and the current culture effectiveness and alignment. The assessment will help to provide measures on how the employees receive the current culture. It includes surveys and pulse checks to evaluate the degree of alignment with organizational values, level of engagement, psychological safety and leadership trust. It provides a broad snapshot of employee sentiment and overall cultural health.

In order to have a clear culture assessment, organization should use CVF model that will categorize the culture in four main types based on two dimensions:

1. Flexibility and direction | stability and control
2. Internal focus and Integration | external focus and differences



These dimensions create four culture quadrants:

- Clan is collaboration and employees focused
- Adhocracy is creativity, innovation and the risks
- Market is competitive and goals
- Hierarchy is structure, process and rules

The CVF Model can measure, visualize and assess the current culture with the desired culture. The standard method uses OCAI survey which asks the leaders and employees to rate the six diminutions of culture. The assessment will happen through collecting data using OCAI.

All employees will be asked to allocate points across for CVF culture types for each of these six dimensions:

1. Dominant characteristics
2. Organizational leadership
3. Organizational glue
4. Strategic emphasis
5. Criteria of success

This survey should be done twice – for the current state and the desired culture. The results then should be plotted in the CVF chat to provide the average scores for each quadrant and visualize which culture is dominant now vs, which is desired. With the analysis the organization can identify the dominant culture where there is too much hierarchy that slows the progress of the organization and decision, or too much adhocracy can cause instability.

Shareholders & Stakeholders Management & Communication Plan

Successful culture transformation requires very active participation from a board range of stakeholders across the organization and beyond. Each group plays a distinct role in shaping and sustains the desired culture (See Table 02 "Culture Audit (Assessment)" & Figure 03 "Culture Communication Plan - below).

Table 02—Culture Audit (Assessment)

Involvement	Role	Why
Executive Leadership	Set the vision and the model desired including behavior	Culture must be supported from the top to gain credibility and organization momentum
Extended Leadership	Translate the vision into daily practices, coach terms, monitor progress	Middle management acts as the link between strategic direction and operational reality,

Involvement	Role	Why
		ensuring culture shifts are embedded and aligned with business needs
Employees at all levels	Adopt new behaviors, contribute to the transition and reinforce the new norms	Culture is a collective behavior, involvement of the employees and the ownership to change
Human Resource (HR)	Design and facilitate the transaction aligning the policies and truck culture matrix	Provides system to embed culture into employee experience
Business units / Contractors	Adopt to the culture and identify barriers	Adopt and ensure the culture transformation is practical and aligned with business needs
Customer(s)	Provide feedback of the effectiveness of the transformation	External perception help validate the internal cultural changes
Board Director	Provide oversight ensure alignment with the strategic objective	Culture influences a long-term performance and reputation that can be provided by the board director's observations.

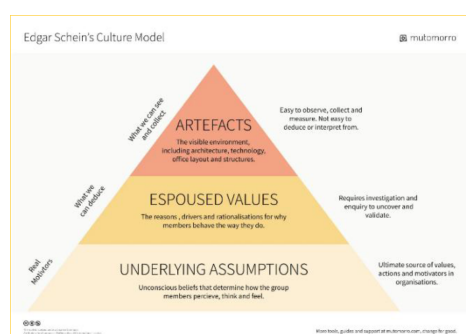


Figure 03—Culture Communication Plan

The involvement of all the above is important as it is an organization wide effort that requires a commitment engagement, operational integration and governance oversight. Involving all of them will guarantee a credible, sustainable change that is aligned with the business strategy and stakeholders expectations.

Leadership Commitment & Alignment

Leadership commitment is a critical factor to the success of culture transformation (See Figure 03 "Culture Communication Plan" above). This section is added to stress on the importance of their alignment, without visible, consistent and authentic support from the top, culture transformation will be on risk. It will be received as a short-term programme rather than a core organizational shift. Involving them in the planning and communication the accountability mechanism is important.

Identify Desired Culture. After the completion of culture audit (Schein's model) and culture assessment through (CVF/OCAI), identifying the desired becomes a structured process of comparing the current state with the strategic need and stakeholder aspiration.

Analyze current state data

- From the culture audit: review the insights, values and underlying assumptions
- From culture assessment: look at CVF results showing the dominant current culture types and the distribution across quadrants

Define the strategic direction

- clarify the organizational future business objectives and operational priorities

- Identify which culture traits will enable the organization goals i.e. innovations, agility, collaboration)

Capture stakeholders' expectations

- Use surveys, interviews and workshops to understand stakeholders and employees' vision for organizational culture.

Identify culture gap

- Highlight where the largest differences occur

Articulated the desired culture profile

- Defined the target mix in the CVF (30% clan, 24 adhocracy, 20% market and 10% hierarchy)
- Translate the identified gaps to behavioral statement (e.g., "leaders coach rather than direct")]

With the above steps the organization will end up with a clear measurable desired culture profile that:

- Aligns with long term strategy
- Reflect stakeholders' aspirations
- Covers both where the organization is now and where they want to be.

Transaction Statement: Section 2.4 above described the methodology used to assess, analyze, and define the current organizational culture, as well as to identify cultural gaps that must be addressed to achieve the desired culture. Typically, an organization may detect several such cultural gaps.

Segment 02 – Section 3.2, "Culture Mapping" twelve (12) key cultural values are identified for transformation as an assumption to this study. These values are then strategically consolidated into six (6) primary cultural competency themes to guide the organization's cultural competency training.



Purpose	:	Create culture change plan that is practical, measurable and aligned with the company value and desired culture
Time Frame	:	3 Month

Design the Culture

Gather comprehensive cultural data to collaboratively plan and implement initiatives aimed at bridging the gap between the current culture and the desired future culture. Furthermore, initiate gap analysis and develop detailed learning plans focused on the competencies and skills needed to drive a sustain cultural transformation. With this approach, organizations can ensure systematic improvement to achieving the desired cultural goals and fostering supportive environment that enhanced habits to transform into practices.

Revamp People Policy and Manual

Upon the completion of a comprehensive culture audit and assessmet supplemented with specific data related to cultural issues from various tools that performed previously in the organization such as yearly

culture survey, turnover and under performance, or it could be an official circulars sent to employees will be a evidence to identify a gap in the leadership communication style than the next step is to conduct a gap analysis.

This culture gap analysis will identify discrepancies between our current practices and the desired organizational culture, without a major overhaul of the entire policy and people manual, especially for multinational organizations.

Given the significance of the proposed culture changes, it may be necessary to undertake a comprehensive review or a complete revamped revision (considering that major changes can add significant values but may also face strong resistance to change).

Once these gaps are identified and culture change is found essential to overhaul the gaps, then the culture workstream team will engage with stakeholders at various levels within the organization.

Transformational Statement: Changes will not be successful with the same mindset used to define the current culture. **Albert Einstein's** "We cannot solve our problems with the same thinking we used when we created them"

As outlined in the above sections 2.2 & 2.3, this engagement will involve a series of discussions and workshops to facilitate a deeper understanding of the desired cultural changes, especially the gap of cultural competencies (e.g. psychological safety, grievance, collaboration, turnovers, integrity, growth mindset). Through this collaborative effort, it must be supplemented with a sense of urgency and leaders must model people policy change (Leadership Visibility)- See [Figure 04](#) & [Table 04](#) "People Policy & Manual Review".

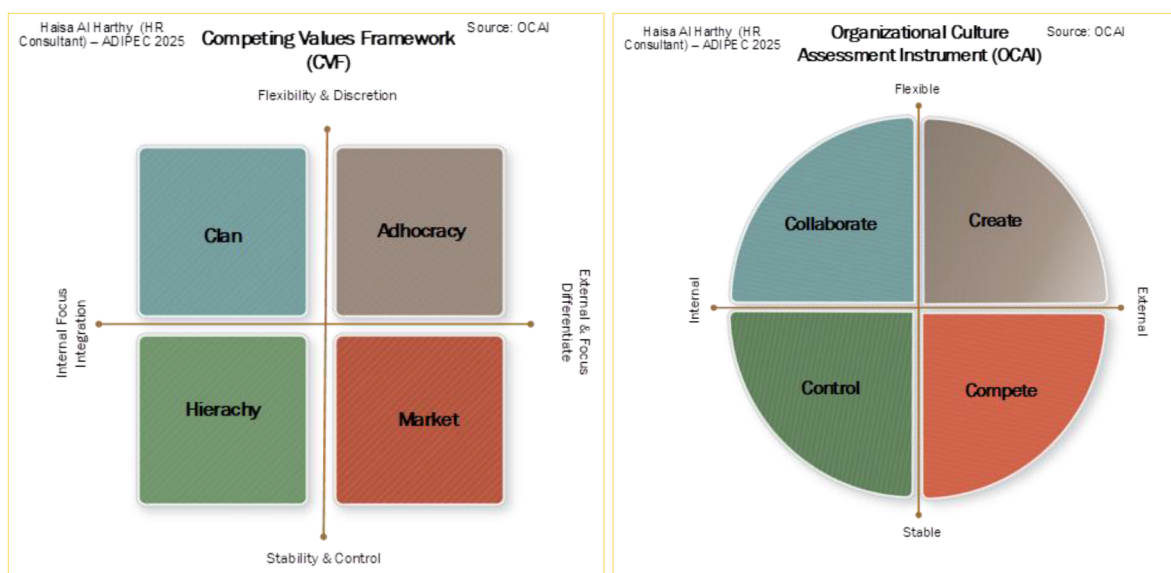


Figure 04 & Table 03—People Policy & Manual Review

Transition Statement: Segment 2 "Culture Design" focuses on designing the culture. At this stage, the organization shall not communicate these cultural changes and the improvement of policy & manual to the wider population, as we are not ready to fly yet. Please limit the changes to cross functional teams and champions. **C.S Lewis** "It may be hard for an egg to turn into bird: it would be a jolly sight harder for it to learn to fly while remaining an egg"

Culture Mapping

Mapping cultural values is a key method for driving sustainable change, enabling organizations to conduct a gap analysis to compare current and desired cultures. In section 2.1 of segment 01, we identified gaps through a culture audit /assessment, than in section 3.1 segment 02 we performed gap analysis, then involved

cross-functional teams and culture champions to address these areas for improvement in our policies and manuals.

At the mapping stage, we required to considered section 2.4 "Identified Desired Culture" – Wishlist to reality (fit for purpose) – than it is necessary to define a culture that aligns with the organization's strategic objectives and to design purposeful cultural values driven to consolidated cultural competencies needs - See Figure 05 "Mapping Desired Culture Values" & 06 - including Table 04 "Establish Culture Competency via Values".

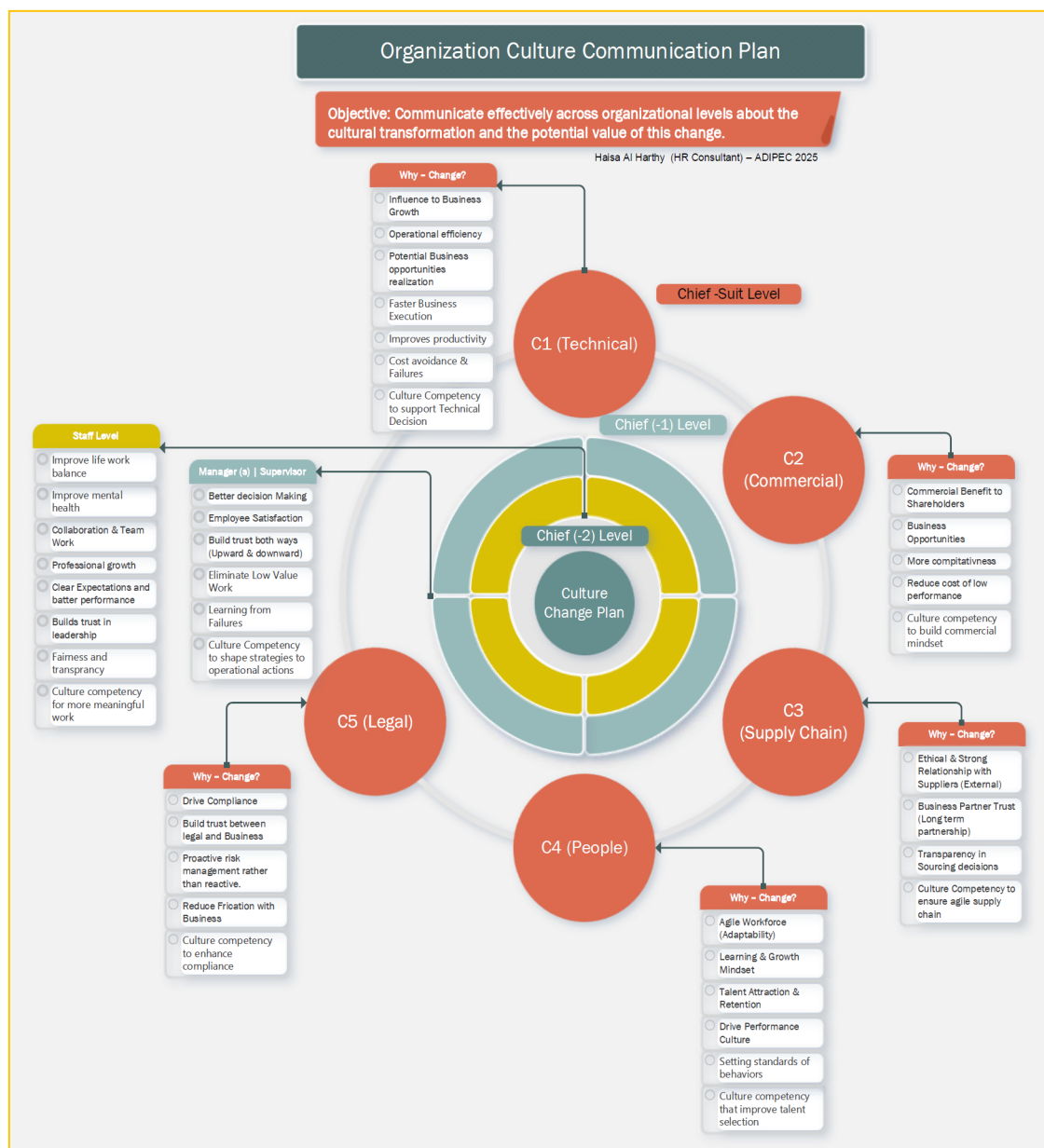


Figure 05—Mapping Desired Culture Values

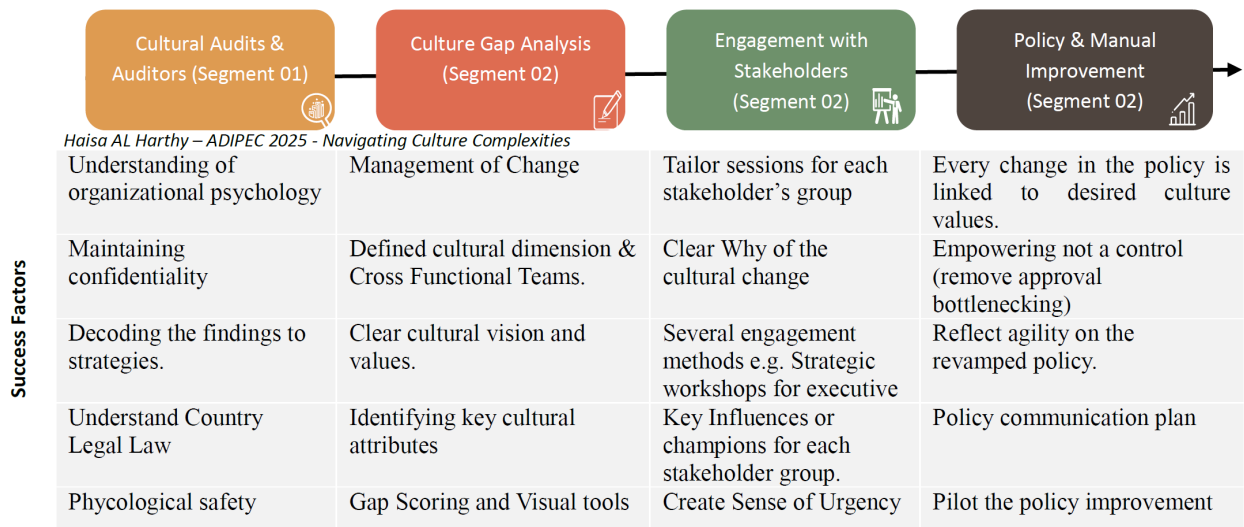


Figure 06 & Table 04—Establish Culture Competency via Values

Transition Statement: Cultural values are influenced by the leader's efforts to support change and accept the stumbled feedback. The quality of deliverables in segments 1 and 2 should align with the overall objectives and strategies. **Joseph Campbell** "Where you stumble, there your treasure is"



Haisa Al Harthy (HR Consultant) – ADIPEC 2025

Culture Competencies

Transition Statement: The next segment will be the time the workstream team to ensure the egg hatches and make the bird fly, with effective engagement (communication) and systematic methodology for implementation.

Organization Desired Culture

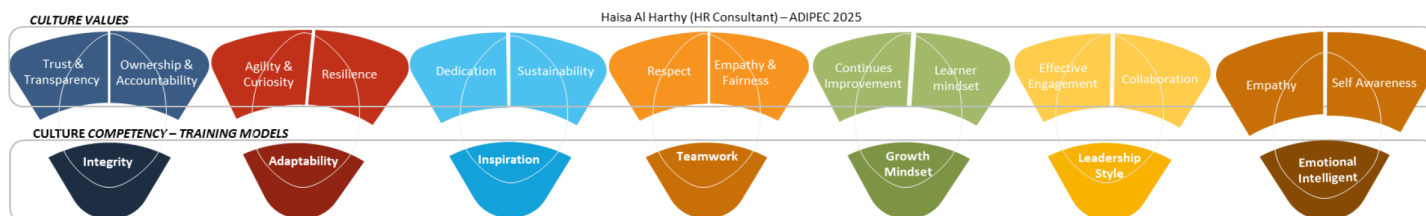
Delivering the desired culture means turning the targeted culture profile from the audit and assessment into visible behavior, system and norms that stick. So once the desired culture is defined the organization must move to consistent day-to-day practice. Which requires a combination of leadership modeling, system alignment and continues reinforce.

- **Leadership modeling the culture:** there should be a specific leadership workshop to align on the expected behavior. Share stories that highlights culture values in action.
- **Align policies, processes and system:** redesign policies to include culture behavior and align programs and recognitions with the target culture
- **Build capabilities though competency – based training**
- **Engage and empower employees:** culture to be co-created to all levels.
- **Communication consistently:** use multi-channels communication to different levels and use every business decision back to culture vision.

Communicate the culture strategy including employee engagement and involvement

Effective communication is essential to ensure that the new culture strategy is understood, embraced and practiced across the organization, communication must be simple, clear and consistent – connected with the desired culture and values. The organization should use different platforms and tools to communicate.

- Townhalls and kick-off events.
- Leaders talking platforms and toolkits.
- Organization digital platforms.
- Office posters and design.
- Learning models.



Reinforce & sustain the transformed culture

To make sure that the culture becomes the DNA of the organization, values, behavior and new ways of work become embedded in the organization daily operation and decision making. Sustaining the change requires a combination of reinforce mechanism and continuing alignment. Organization must embed the culture in the system and processes starting from onboarding and hiring process. A continuation of leadership role modeling and on-going communication to the different level of the organization.

Reflect the Culture to Performance Review

As a part of sustaining the new culture, performance management system must be used as a tool. The culture values should be linked to the yearly objective along-side with performance goals. At least one or two values should be added in the KPI. Embedding the desired culture directly into how performance is measured it will keep the new culture alive.

Establish Culture Reward and Recognition Scheme

A well-designed reward scheme will defiantly reinforce values and behavior. Celebrating and incentivizing culture alignment will maintain the momentum, motivate employees and make the culture real. The award should be visible and inclusive for culture.

Culture Sustainability & Competency Based Training

To make the culture value life across the design of a framework is one of the best solutions:

Where each training module should be designed like "learning lab" where participants not only understand the culture value but practice the competency through scenarios that reflect their day-to-day role.

Structure of the Training Module. Every module follows a consistent structure as elaborated in [Table 05](#) "Training Model Structure":

Table 05—Training Model Structure

No	Module	Focus
1.	Culture Values	What does it mean to the organization and why it matters strategically?
2.	Culture Competencies	What behavior translates the value into actions
3.	Learning Objectives	What should the participant know, do and demonstrate by the end of the learning
4.	Application Tools	Methods to bring to life (case study and role-plays, simulation and reflection exercise and peer coaching
5.	Outcome	What practical change should participants apply back on the job

Example of implementing training module. Using organization culture plan in 2.2 section

Embedding a lasting culture value into the company requires practical experience where different management levels can experiment, reflect and apply in alignment with identified culture competencies. To achieve this a culture training programme will be delivered using learning hubs model, where culture values are translated into competencies and practical through immersive real-world scenario. Each training module is built on a culture value with tailored competencies depending on the management level.

Unlike traditional training which focuses on values or tools that are not tailored to specific target group transferring knowledge, a learning hub is an exceptional learning environment where the target group/employees will practice values-based behavior through real scenarios.

This approach ensures employees not only develop their competences but to live them every day. This model is built on the results of cultural value and that were agreed upon the cultures assessment and audit - See [Figure 07](#) "Establish Culture Competency via Values (Training Models)".

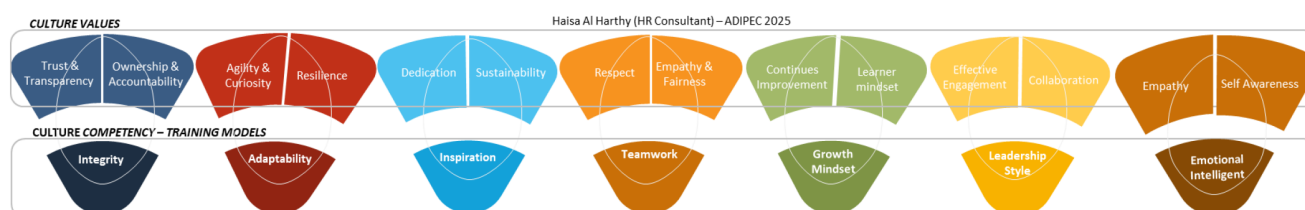


Figure 07—Establish Culture Competency via Values (Training Models)

Since there are seven values identified, they do not serve as a single set of core value/ competencies for the entire company. Instead, the model applies one focused culture competency that is tailored to each target group, while also ensuring that two (2) or additional competencies are selected as a learning requirement.

This approach allows the organization to address the unique priorities of different groups, while still fostering shared growth in key competencies that build alignment across the whole organization.

Table 06—Establish Culture Competency (Example)

Culture Value	Culture Competency	Management Level	Learning Objectives	Application tools	Expected outcome
Effective Engagement and Collaboration	(Leadership style) drive alignment and develop people in all levels	C1- Operation Group	- Defined leadership beyond authority - Practice coaching and empowerment - Learn to communicate organization vision	Case study: - transactional vs transformational leadership - coaching under performance	- Inspire confidence - Develop talent and role model company values
Ownership & Accountability Trust and Transparency	(Integrity) how to make ethical decisions under pressure and act	C2 - Commercial & Legal Group	- Recognize ethical dilemmas at work - Apply integrity in decision-making situations	Case study: - Financial reporting dilemmas. - Role play: saying no for unethical request	- Managing dilemmas with confidence. - Stronger trust from the teams
Empathy & Self-awareness	(Emotional intelligence)	C3- Supply Chain Group	- Increase awareness of personal emotional triggers - Practice empathy and active listening	- Reflection: EI self-assessment - Case study: conflict resolved through EI.	Strengthen trust, reduce conflicts and create psychological

Conclusion

Culture competency is tailored by management level mindset and grounded diagnose insights is essential for driving the sustained culture change, despite the complexity of defining the competency will enable the organization to emend the transformation of culture - **See Figure 08" Culture Competency Themes (Programme)"**.

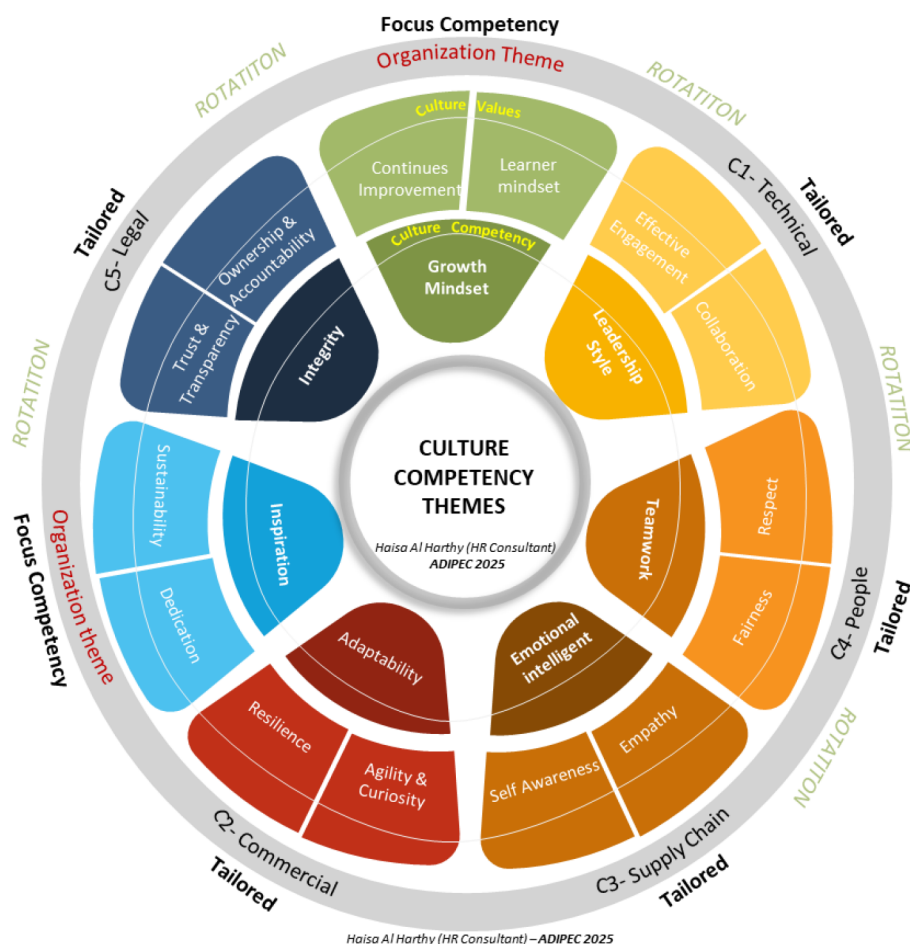


Figure 08—Culture Competency Themes (Programme)

Additive information

This Paper introduce a novel approach to culture change by combining competency base training (differentiated by management level) with structured sustainable reinforcement plan.

The culture transformation procedure will ensure long term culture integration, extending the desire behavior into policy system, leaderships practices and daily operations.

Learning Outcome

Leaders and Employees will be able to recognize and adopt to culture complexities by diagnosing the misalignment, adjusting leadership approaches and communicate the different styles – aligning the values to foster cohesive and resilient culture integrating values and competencies across diverse context while applying the competency based practices that embed the culture into daily operations, processes and behaviors, ensuring culture is sustained as a living system. There will be no organizational transformation without a focus.

Way Forward

To successfully embed the culture transformation the organization, need to move from values as statements to values as lived behavior, reinforced though a competency-based training farmwork. This approach ensures that employees and leaders at all levels can recognize, practice and sustain culture competencies

Next Step:

- Translate the values into competencies: competencies should be tailored to management level and function(s).

- Develop learning hubs: training to be designed around a real scenario, case studied and toolkit.
- Monitor and Reinforce: through engagement surveys, performance KPI, recognitions and leadership communication.

Acknowledgment

I would like to extend my sincere appreciation to the leaders in my organization, colleagues in different organizations locally and globally including the co-chairs who reviewed the manuscript specifically **Syed Mohammad Raza** for his feedback and ideas to add a new perspective in the values. Additionally, I would like to thank **Dharmik Sanghrajka** for his support. This work would not have been done without your support and belief in the importance of culture.